

The **NEVER ENOUGH** Formula

How to **eradicate** the **internal
terror** of **never feeling good
enough** in **4 proven steps**.

**ANTI
IMPOSTER
CLUB**

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Here is the problem...

Dear reader,

I first and foremost want to thank you for making the time and effort to download this eBook. Given how fast paced our lives are these days, how short our attention spans have become and how intense the number of ads is that bombard us each minute that we're awake, it really means something to me that you stopped scrolling and decided to give me a chance to help you finally feel good enough *again*.

Because you already did once, remember?

If you were anything like me when you were younger, you used to walk around with two different-coloured shoelaces, have golden tips in your hair, funky patterns cut into your skin fade and pretend to be Ash from Pokémon. And you never once questioned how you were perceived by others. You were oblivious to the other people's looks or frowns. You never once thought about whether you were weird or meeting society's standards. You were just being you. Unapologetically and carelessly. And that was good enough.

However, at some point (and most of us can't even pin down exactly when) things changed. Suddenly, you started feeling insecure about things that had never been an issue for you, like your physique, your hairline, or whether being 5'11 is too short. You started worrying about how to be as successful as all these 21-year-old drop shipping millionaires serenading you to watch one 'How-To' YouTube video after the next. You started stressing about the advice from all these motivational speakers, who keep telling you to "find your purpose", "follow

your passion”, “be your best self” and “live your best life”. You started questioning why the others have it all figured out and you don’t, what it is that you are missing and why your attempts to follow their advice doesn’t bring you the same success. And so slowly but surely, the belief grew in you that maybe you are just not good enough, that maybe there is something wrong with you. Sound familiar?

As it turns out my friend, us two are not the only ones struggling with these issues. A survey of 2000 millennials from 2019 shows that 8 out of 10 people don’t feel good enough anymore¹. As of 2021, in the UK, over 80% of both women and men don’t believe they’re attractive, intelligent, or likeable². And *worldwide* only 11% of girls feel comfortable using the word “beautiful” to describe themselves³.

People feel under pressure these days. In a world where social media has made us more similar than ever, the trend has accelerated of having to stand out from the crowd, of being special and ‘different’. Living a ‘normal’ life of being full-time employed in a well-paying job is all of a sudden not good enough anymore. Instead, you should be working on your ‘passion project’ until 3 am in the morning, hit the gym every day of the week to sculpt your Adonis body and spend all your cash on endless dreamy vacations because ‘life’s too short to be unhappy’. And if you don’t, you best believe that Instagram and other social media platforms will serve up a plethora of seemingly perfect lives that people portray on their accounts to remind you that you are failing in life.

Worryingly, this has had a serious impact on people’s mental health. We have become overly critical of ourselves. We downgrade our achievements. We feel

¹<https://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/home-news/millennials-mental-health-love-young-adults-social-media-pol-l-alpro-a9181296.html>

²<https://geehair.com/blogs/blog/self-confidence-statistics-uk-2021-2022>

³<https://gitnux.org/self-esteem-statistics/#:~:text=Highlights%3A%20Self%20Esteem%20Statistics&text=About%2049%25%20of%20teenagers%20feel,%E2%80%9Cbeautiful%E2%80%9D%20to%20describe%20themselves.>

like our opinions and ideas aren't as valuable as those of others. We believe that others are more intelligent than us. And we set ridiculously high expectations for ourselves, thinking that only once we have reached perfection in everything we do, we will finally find our self-worth. This pattern of thinking is often summarised as the **Imposter Syndrome**⁴, and it has created more anxiety, depression, and feelings of inadequacy than ever. Which has given rise to, in my opinion, pretty scary behaviours.

On the one hand, people have decided that if they can't be exceptional in a positive way, they can go to other extremes. They can choose to victimise themselves, making their life way worse than it needs to be to gain some form of special treatment they crave. Ever noticed how much people are complaining these days? How everyone is constantly searching for the negatives in a situation? How quick people are to diagnose themselves with depression, anxiety, or any other mental illness? (Even when they haven't actually got it, which I always think is a bit disrespectful towards those who do actually have it).

On the other hand, people have developed an unsatisfiable hunger - if not addiction - for self-improvement.

A survey found that 94% of Millennials, 81% of Gen Xers and 84% of Boomers are working on some form of self-improvement⁵. People read one self-improvement book after the other, listen to one podcast episode after the next, and watch endless amounts of motivational speeches, in their quest to find the holy grail that will finally fix their never-ending list of self-imposed issues.

⁴<https://yougov.co.uk/topics/society/articles-reports/2022/06/07/how-many-britons-display-signs-impostor-syndrome>; <https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/321730#symptoms>; <https://www.verywellmind.com/imposter-syndrome-and-social-anxiety-disorder-4156469#toc-coping-with-imposter-syndrome>

⁵<https://blog.fieldagent.net/millennials-boomers-new-years-resolutions-5-key-generational-differences>

Have a quick think about yourself? What was your Insta or Facebook feed filled with before you tapped on my ad?

Now, I believe that self-improvement in itself isn't a bad thing, and I highly encourage people to become aware of one's weaknesses and take proactive action to address them. But, I also believe that the constant over-exposure to self-improvement content is incredibly toxic. Because what most people don't realise is this: The mere engagement with self-help techniques creates the automatic perception of yourself to be 'less good'.

Consider this for example: Standing in front of a mirror and repeating affirmations saying that you're beautiful suggests that you're not beautiful already. (Otherwise you wouldn't have to tell yourself). Following relationship advice makes you focus on the traits that you perceive to make you less lovable and makes you forget about all the things that do make you lovable already. Doing visualisation exercises to become more successful distracts you from appreciating everything that you have achieved already.

In other words, engaging with self-help in an excessive way redirects your focus from all things that are already good about yourself to all your apparent deficiencies.

To quote one of my favourite authors, Mark Manson, from his book *The subtle art of not giving a fuck*:

*"When you stop and really think about it, conventional life advice – all the happy self-help stuff we hear all the time – is actually fixating on what you **lack**."*

Thus, learning about how to be happy, confident, or successful is actually a constant subconscious suggestion to yourself that you are not all these things already, thereby ironically feeding your self-doubt.

However, victim-mentality and self-improvement addiction aside. Because the biggest issue of all, which underpins our tendencies to not feel good enough and runs like a red thread through all the above points, is this: ***We give way too many fucks about how we are perceived by others.***

Now, in general caring about what others think isn't a bad thing. Dale Carnegie, author of the global bestseller *How to make friends and influence people*, makes it clear that one of the core natural desires of any human being is ***to mean something to someone***. We naturally care about what others think of us and we naturally want to fit in and have a feeling of belonging. Because community offers safety and comfort.

However, in our society the desire to win the approval of others has reached new extremes. It almost feels as if this search for external validation has effectively become our only source of satisfaction. We have stopped reflecting on what it is that *we* actually want and on what makes *us* genuinely happy. We don't even know what our ***intrinsic*** wants are anymore. We have stopped seeking the approval that we want for our goals, behaviours, and even our thoughts from ***ourselves*** and instead, have programmed ourselves to be people-pleasers, who are entirely focused on ***the others***. On meeting the expectations of ***the others***, satisfying the needs of ***the others***, worrying about the feelings and problems of ***the others***, hoping that doing so will enable us to win their approval and thereby find happiness and contentment. Dangerous. Because by doing so you are not only putting your entire happiness in the hands of someone else, but you are also trying to solve an impossible task. Let me explain.

What most people don't realise is that, while the need to mean something to someone is an important one to satisfy, we don't need the approval from everyone to do so. ***The mere approval from the people in our tribe – our family, friends, or colleagues that we respect, i.e., those who actually mean something to***

us – is enough (I think you would agree that a single compliment from one of your best friends who you respect and maybe even look up to has infinitely more weight than 1,000 likes from (let's be honest) mere acquaintances on your last Insta post, right?).

However, with being more connected than ever through social media, **our brain assumes that our tribe is infinitely bigger than it actually is**. As a result, the task of winning the approval of others has become impossible to complete. Unfortunately, most people are unaware of this reality. And so they keep trying to please everyone, stay distracted from what and who really matters, and as a result never feel good enough.

Time to break out of this vicious cycle.

The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula

The goal of this eBook is not to give you another one of those lists of shallow short-term fixes that the internet is full of these days, like '5 hacks to disarm high self-expectations, etc.' but rather redirect your focus to addressing the far deeper behavioural patterns that are the cause of your diminishing self-esteem.

Now, realistically I am not going to make you change your entire mindset within the space of 40-odd pages. And spoiler alert: It is going to take a lot of work on your side to make that happen. However, I can at least nudge you in the right direction.

Throughout my journey of 'self-improvement', I have found that oftentimes a single thought, quote, or sentence is enough to connect the dots, to create the right epiphany, and to motivate you enough to take the action that you should have taken years ago to take yourself to a better place. Hence, I want to share

with you, in distilled form, some of the most influential thoughts and ideas that I have encountered and formed for myself throughout my journey of rediscovering my self-esteem, hoping that they will provide you with the same kind of value.

"A Man Cannot Be Comfortable without His Own Approval." - Mark Twain

My main intention is in that context for you to stop feeling like an imposter and fight the inner thinking pattern that comes with that. I want to make you realise again that you are already good enough the way you are. I want you to stop assuming that you are worse than others and stop comparing your inner self to the outer picture of others (which is in 100% of cases incomplete, unnaturally polished, and to some extent fake). Yes, they may seem more confident, but are they really? And as a result, I want to make you **reinstate a healthy balance** between seeking approval from others and seeking it from yourself.

Now, I am not an extremist who is going to tell you that you should entirely stop caring about everyone but yourself and isolate yourself from everyone who even in the slightest doesn't align with what I am about to share with you. Because, first of all, you're not going to do that anyway, and second of all, you shouldn't do that. We are all social animals who need good people around us and that requires making an effort with them and putting our needs behind theirs. Plus, being a natural people-pleaser really is an honourable trait to have! Who would we become as a society if we didn't have people with a good heart, (which all people-pleasers have), who show genuine care for those around them, who are that friend that is always there when we need a helping hand or an open ear?

However, as you will find out in the following pages there really is a problem with being "too nice" and always putting everyone else's needs before your own. Hence, I want you to start people-pleasing in the right way. I want you to

redirect your focus away from pleasing *everyone* and towards your tribe and most importantly **yourself**. I want to make you realise that your own approval is so much more important than that of anyone else. And as a side effect of this realisation help you naturally start valuing yourself more, boost your self-esteem and rediscover feeling good enough.

In other words, I want you to stop being an approval-seeker who makes satisfying the others' needs their main purpose in life, hoping that it will bring you the contentment you seek. Because here's another mind-fuck for you: Being a total people-pleaser paradoxically makes you less likeable, which feeds your self-doubt even more!

The problem is that when you are being a total people-pleaser, you actually end up being **incredibly selfish**. Because when you are being a people-pleaser you're constantly overthinking what the others think of you, what would be the best thing to say or do to make them like you more, and what you shouldn't do so you don't upset them or come across as critical.

In other words, as a people-pleaser, ***you're always thinking about yourself, not them***. And that is incredibly distracting in every possible sense. People-pleasing prevents you from really listening to and empathising with the other person. It prevents you from sharing your honest opinion, which may not always be what the other person wants to hear, but which they may need to hear, and which in turn may give you their respect and approval on a much deeper level. And that is what you wanted to achieve in the first place, right?

It sounds paradoxical but by ***being less focused on how the others perceive you, you free your mind to actually worry about them better and be a more helpful, more present, and more authentic person that people want to hang out with.***

So how do we get there?

Step 1:

Start with Rejection

Let me start by asking you a question: On a scale of 'No, no, no!' to 'I'd catch a grenade for ya', how easy is it for you to say 'no'? In other words, how easy is it for you to reject someone?

Using myself as an example, I'll tell you that not too long ago, I was an absolute 'Yes-man' and one of the nicest guys you'll ever meet. I would absolutely detest the idea of potentially upsetting someone by turning down their ask for help or a favour. I hated the idea of initiating a difficult conversation with someone and telling them how I really felt out of fear that it would cause a massive conflict. I kept all my opinions to myself (or not even have any in the first place) and just agree with everything the others said to keep the peace, make everyone happy and avoid conflict at all costs. And when I failed and ended in a conflict I panicked, took unhealthy over-responsibility for the other people's feelings, extensively analysed how I behaved in the situation and constantly thought "Ah I should have said this, I should have done that, etc." so that next time I could be an even better people-pleaser and conflict-avoider.

Even now writing this down makes me cringe a little. It took me way too long to realise this one core truth everyone needs to embrace: ***Life gets better through rejection*** (both through receiving it, but also through giving it).

The conventional advice goes that we should "be inherently accepting and affirmative, say yes to everything and everyone" ...and completely ignore that

doing so will give rise to an incredible threat: ***Our life essentially becomes meaningless.***

Because if we don't reject anything and anyone and pick doing everything, really, we end up with nothing. No focus. No direction. No purpose. And for that matter ***no identity***. And that's incredibly problematic.

Because it is that feeling of ***knowing where you are going in life***, of ***knowing what's important to you***, and for that matter, of ***knowing who you are*** which is a prerequisite for being rewarded with what I call the **currencies of self-esteem**.

Key Lesson:

The currencies of self-esteem are what I consider to be the true sources of feeling good enough, secure in yourself, confident, and comfortable in your own skin, i.e., all the things that I want to help you rediscover with this eBook.

I say 'true' sources because as opposed to other currencies such as Instagram likes and TikTok comments, the currencies of self-esteem don't come from external sources but like the word **self**-esteem suggests from within. They are things that nobody can give you but yourself. They are outcomes that result from your own actions only, not anyone else's, like ***progress, learning from failures, uniqueness over others, trust, genuine love, the depth of a relationship or understanding for a topic***. And that makes them incredibly powerful. Because this *self-created* value, this *self-created* evidence that you are on the right track and good enough the way you are is what provokes far more long-lasting improvements in your self-perception.

And you have already experienced their power in action, whether you were aware of it or not.

Do you remember the incredible confidence boost you got from hitting a new personal best in the sport that you do? Or that energising feeling you got from realising your uniqueness over others at work because you have more knowledge than anyone else on a certain topic? Or that deep sense of security you felt as you realised the depth of the relationship you have built with your friends and the trust you all have towards each other that makes you a real collective force?

These things all come from your own actions, from your consistent training, from studying in your free time, from making an effort with your friends.

And if you realise it or not, these things also come from rejection.

They come from ***dedicating yourself*** to certain relationships, jobs, or hobbies and ***rejecting all the alternatives***, hindrances and distractions.

Have a quick think. What did it take for you to become the athlete, the expert in your work, or the valued friend that you are?

Was it turning down the boozy bottomless brunch with the girls to stay in shape? Cancelling the Tinder dates to have enough time to study and build your expertise? Or not going to the parties, to help one of your best friends move to a new place, despite all the ‘baddies’ you could have met there?

Whatever it was, I would bet a whole McDonald’s Happy Meal, that it involved some form of rejection.

And that may have not always been easy and may have come with the occasional FOMO, guilt, or doubts. But ***it is that rejection that really defines us***, that reinforces who we are and what we stand for, and that rewards us with the currencies of self-esteem.

Only by giving all his time and attention to his training and rejecting going out drinking, chasing girls, or taking days off to chill was Muhammed Ali able to develop the lightning-fast punches that earned him the uniqueness of being one of the greatest boxers of all time. Only by committing to making things work and rejecting any temptation to let their eyes wander elsewhere when things got tough between them to preserve their loyalty has that cute elderly couple you see walking on the street been able to earn the seemingly unbreakable relationship that so many of us are longing for. Those are things that no baddie will ever be able to give you. Hence, if you are wanting to rediscover your self-esteem, you have to learn to be selective.

In fact, the opposite, the act of trying to avoid rejection at all costs and the conflict that comes with it, is actually a form of entitlement and a sign of cowardice. It basically shows to others that you think that you deserve to feel great all the time, while at the same time hiding your own fear of rejection and discomfort of being confronted. I am guilty of that, too. If I am being completely honest with myself, the only reason I had always been so afraid of rejecting or even just confronting someone else was that deep down I was too afraid of being rejected by them in return. Even when I knew that my long-term relationship with my ex-girlfriend had gotten incredibly toxic, I'd still rather live with the fact that I was trying absolutely everything to make things work between us because then, in my head, I could blame everything on her, when really, I was just too afraid that she would reject me after I rejected her first. So, I was trying to avoid that risk by letting her take the lead and stayed with her longer than was good for both our mental health.

Don't make the same mistake as me. To put it into Mark Manson's words: "There are only limited fucks that you can give in life". Save them for who and what is genuinely important to you, like family, *real* friends, the *right* partner, and your real life goals. Don't be a coward like I was and learn to reject the alternatives.

Otherwise, you end up with second-rated friendships, a merely “alright” relationship, and doing things that are not really your priority.

In other words, you live a life that’s not lived to its full potential. A scary thought if you ask me.

To rewrite the old adage: ***good things come to those who reject.***

Plus, there is another reason why rejection is so important:

Nobody knows what is good for you, apart from you.

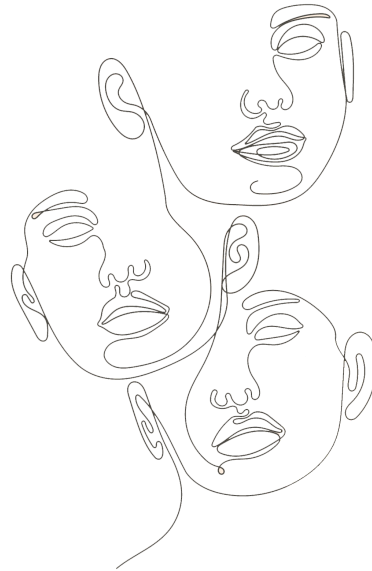
You will no doubt have found yourself in several situations in life where people have tried to give you advice. Or worse. Where people have tried to tell you what to do because they “knew” that it would be good for you. Personally, I used to give other people’s advice way too much weight, even when I didn’t know them. I used to be very easily convinced that I should do ‘this’ or that I should be like ‘that’ because I for some reason considered my advisors as smarter, more experienced, of higher status, wiser, and so on. And they might have been and probably were!

But see, the thing is, no matter how smart, wise, or experienced someone giving you advice is, ***they don’t live in your reality.*** They don’t see the world through your eyes. They don’t use the same value-compass and intrinsic decision-making criteria that you use. In other words, they don’t really know you. And here is why:

The Japanese say you have three faces. The first face, you show to the world. The second face, you show to your close friends and your family. The third face, you never show to anyone. However, it is that last face that is the ***truest reflection of who you are.*** It is that last face that holds our true moral compass, that

determines our true priorities, and that holds our *truest* desires and wants. But if we never show our third face to anyone, how can anybody know what really matters to us and therefore tell us how to get there? I.e., how is anybody supposed to know what is good for us?

They don't. Period.



To digress a little into human psychology, humans are, in general, terrible at predicting things. We are full of bias that heavily distorts our perception of reality and makes us worryingly overconfident in the truth of our opinions. We fail to accept that nobody knows anything, that most of the time we are wrong, and that as we learn we just become less wrong. I love those statistics which reveal that a fully-fledged Wall Street trader has got virtually no better prediction abilities on where the stock market is going to go than the yellow cab driver that takes him to the office every morning⁶. And yet everyone would rather listen to the Wall Street trader when it comes to investing advice. We are biased to think that because of factors such as higher status, expensive suits or good looks people have more knowledge, when in reality, they don't.

And that applies to any domain, but is especially true when it comes to giving advice.

⁶The Black Swan: The Impact of the Highly Improbable - Nassim Nicholas Taleb

Thus, whatever someone else thinks is good for us doesn't have to be true (and in most cases almost definitely isn't). And so ***we don't have to listen to it – we are allowed to reject anyone's advice or opinion*** (it felt incredibly freeing when I first realised this). And not only are you allowed to do that, I ***urge*** you to do that.

Because ***only you know what works for you***. Whether it's the type of diet and exercise to lose weight, the learning method that will help you pass exams or the passion that you should pursue to find a sense of fulfilment in life. We are all so different that no matter how much you try to act like others or according to their advice, chances are that you won't achieve the same results as them. All it will do is make you feel out of place, and you'll end up being inauthentic.

I am not saying you should never ever listen to anyone else's advice ever again because we are all experts in our own domains and have far more experience and knowledge on certain topics than others that we can pass on. And it is fair to say that if I hadn't taken on the advice from the books I have read and the podcasts I have listened to, I wouldn't be where I am today. However, what I am suggesting is to not simply take someone else's words for the truth. Sure, others can guide you and make you aware of different options, like training styles, learning techniques, etc. but in the end, ***it must be you who chooses and approves*** of them. Only a few options work for you and it is your responsibility to figure out which ones they are and reject the ones that aren't. ***Only your own approval and your own validation will bring the results, not anyone else's. Only you know what is good for yourself.***

Start taking responsibility right now. Consider everything I am saying in this eBook and question whether the advice I have got to give is actually useful to you and reject it if not. That is your perfect right. I won't be offended...(maybe only a little).

Step 2:

Be selfish

How do you feel about people who are selfish? Like that guy who skips the queue at passport control at the airport. Or the co-worker who will try to get the most air time in a meeting. Do you despise them? Consider them as careless and rude?

I imagine you are not the only one. Being selfish and self-centred often comes with a pretty bad stigma in today's society. And there is no doubt about the fact that there are plenty of people out there these days who consider themselves as far more important than others when they have got no real right to think that way. However, we can't deny that those arrogant fellows are often bursting with incredible confidence, right?

Well, it turns out we can learn a thing or two from them. Because they have understood a key lesson of our psychology (whether they are aware of it or not) that the rest of us are yet to learn or at least to stop ignoring. And that is: ***Being selfish is a fundamental element of feeling good enough and with that your overall well being.***

Let's digress with another little lesson from the realm of psychology to understand this better.

Embrace the whole you.

Back in the 1920s, when your doctor could still prescribe you alcohol as treatment for your depression (not kidding!)⁷, an Austrian psychologist with a keen interest in the human psyche published a theory that would completely change the way we see ourselves. The arguments of this theory were so convincing in fact that since its publishing it has become a real staple in the studies of psychology that is taught in schools and universities all over the world today. Which is always a bit funny to me because if you really think about it, what this legendary psychologist, named Sigmund Freud, and his ‘personality theory’ suggests is that we are all a bit insane...

According to Freud our personality is made up of three little voices occupying our mind, which are called the ‘Id’, the ‘Ego’ and the ‘Superego’ (Yes, you read that right, you can finally stop worrying about whether you are going insane when you are hearing voices!). And, jokes aside, each one of these ‘voices’ has got a very important task for our wellbeing.

The Id, on the one hand, is like your shadow that always has your back when it comes to fulfilling your most intrinsic wants. It is the advocate for all your most unfiltered instincts, impulses, and desires, and is trying to make sure that you are getting these met. However, unfortunate for those around you, that also includes the ones that most of us (unless you’re a psychopath) would deem as undesirable and unacceptable, like aggression, revenge, or the desire to dominate. In that context, the Id is also incredibly selfish and impatient. It wants everything that is pleasurable, and it wants it now, not caring about any sort of rules, what others think, or the long-term implications of its actions on others.

⁷<https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/during-prohibition-your-doctor-could-write-you-prescription-booze-180947940/>

Hence, to make you a somewhat pleasant human being that is capable of peacefully living with others, you also have the Superego. The Superego is like your halo that comprises all the qualities that you have been taught make you a 'good person'. It is your inner moral police that wants you to do what's first and foremost good for society and the others and prevent your Id from releasing all its immoral impulses. For that purpose, it is also the voice of self-criticism that tells you when you're doing something 'wrong' and punishes you with feelings of guilt and self-doubt to make sure you really learn the lesson.

And then there is the Ego. The Ego is like your mental judge sitting in-between the Id and the Superego. It tries to find common ground, making sure that both the Id and Superego get what they desire.

Because we need both of them. They're both irremovable parts of us and ensure that we stay in a healthy balance between meeting our truest inner desires while at the same time being a safe and valuable contributor to our tribe's well-being and progress⁸.



⁸<https://www.simplypsychology.org/psyche.html>; <https://www.verywellmind.com/the-id-ego-and-superego-2795951>

However, the problem with most people is that their Superego has become way too good at convincing the Ego what to do. It has become way too good at making you feel guilty about your undesirable wants and therefore at telling you to suppress your Id. And that is very dangerous.

Because as you are suppressing your Id to prevent all kinds of undesirable and unacceptable behaviour such as revenge and aggression, you actually end up suppressing **ALL** your intrinsic wants. And that means that in effect that you are starving yourself of part of your personality and prevent yourself from being your true self. Risky move.

Because the more you suppress something, the more it grows. The more you are building up this uncomfortable pressure inside that we all know, which tells you that something is wrong (even when you don't know exactly what). And if you don't find a valve to release it, this pressure will start eating you up from the inside. You will start having inexplicable physical pain, mental health issues, like anxiety or depression, and feelings of insecurity as you surrender yourself to self-doubt and thinking patterns like the Imposter Syndrome. You are prone to ending up in a vicious cycle of always putting the others' needs and wants before your own, and thereby (without even realising) constantly suggesting to yourself that your needs are worth less, and therefore that YOU are worth less, than the others.

Side Note: Do you ever wake up with a bad back or an inexplicable neck pain? Well, believe it or not, the reason for this might actually not be that you laid a bit weirdly last night. Rather the physical pain is your body's way of distracting you from a mental issue, such as not being your true self. It's its own attempt to somehow release the uncomfortable pressure that comes with suppressing your intrinsic needs and wants.

Time to stop voting against yourself.

I hope the above makes clear that being selfish is an absolutely crucial part of a healthy mind. Without it we are setting ourselves up for damaging ourselves, including our sense of being good enough.

Being selfish doesn't mean being an arrogant asshole. ***Being selfish means knowing that your needs are important and wanting to meet them because you deem yourself as valuable and deserving of that.*** It means realising that you mustn't constantly prioritise other people's needs and diminish your own. And it also means indulging in self-acceptance. It means admitting to yourself that you have certain qualities (because we all do) that are maybe not desirable in society but that are important parts of us regardless. And that doesn't make us a bad person!

So, let's stop suppressing them. Let's embrace selfishness, and as we will see, harvest the currencies of self-esteem that come with that.

Know what you want.

At the core of being selfish is something I have referred to a couple of times by now: ***Knowing what we want.*** Now, because we have been driven to be so fixated on pleasing the others, worrying about their needs, and hoping that doing so will enable us to win the others' approval, it can be really hard to know sometimes what it is that we truly want. However, it is incredibly important to find out.

Because wanting something is one of the most basic aspects of nature. It is the major driving force for anything in this world. Your wants define what's going to make you happy. They determine your actions and which direction you're going

to go when facing a crossroads in life. And they are also the starting point for building your self-esteem.

Because only as you form your goals and wants, you give yourself something to dedicate yourself to. Only as you explore what your Id really desires are you able to figure out what to be selfish about. Only with a clear goal in mind can you start prioritising all the activities that will help you achieve it. And as we have seen above, it is this dedication to something, the knowing what you stand for, the knowing what's important to you and the act of rejecting the alternatives and hindrances that is an incredible source of feeling secure and confident, and which reward you with the currencies of self-esteem, e.g., the progress you feel as you work towards your goal, the sense of power you experience as you learn from failures and overcome obstacles, and the uniqueness you feel as you reach your objectives.

Think about all the great men and women that are oozing with self-confidence. The Jordan Petersons and Michelle Obamas. They all have one thing in common. They all act with purpose. They have dedicated themselves to fulfilling a vision. It is that vision that gives them something to dedicate themselves to. It is that clarity of their wants that gives them something to be selfish about and draw confidence from.

Hence, to become more selfish and build the self-esteem that comes with that, think about what it is that your Id really desires. (Check out <https://www.antiimposterclub.com/aic-cookbook/> for a personalised step-by-step guide on how to figure out what you want – but only after you finished chapter 4 in this eBook).

For starters, have a think about: What do I love? What do I hate? What do I believe in? What is my purpose? What are my values? And how can I form those answers into my wants in life?

Importantly, recognise that ***there is no judgement behind wanting something, it can never be right or wrong.*** You either want something, or you don't. That's it. So, own who you are, what you like, what you believe in, and what you want, and then...express it.

Express what you want

I want to zoom in on something that I feel gets often overlooked but is a real secret to heightening your sense of being good enough. Because doing what I am about to dive into allows you to actively signal yourself that your needs – and therefore YOU – are important. While at the same time, allowing you to build deeper connections with people, which is one of the strongest currencies of self-esteem out there. Let's talk about ***expressing what you want.***

Too many of us spend their time in a passive communication style. They just stay silent, don't say out loud what it is they want, and let everyone else make the decisions, hoping that if they are nice enough the others will give them what they want without them having to ask for it. Or worse, they will be really indirect about it and 'drop hints', hoping that the others will pick up on what they are implying and give it to them. Not only is this approach highly ineffective in getting your needs met but, surprise, people also absolutely hate that kind of behaviour.

See, the thing is ***others actually want to meet your needs!*** Just like you are always naturally trying to figure out how to please the others, the others are trying to do the same to you. Because another important aspect of our psychology is this:

We build much deeper connections with the people we invest a lot of time and effort in. But if you don't give others the chance to do so by being hard to read and not allowing others to meet your needs, you are denying them to build those connections with you. In fact, you are provoking the opposite, and push them away as they end up feeling frustrated from not being able to connect with you. Ultimately, not sharing your wants will thereby also prevent you from building your sense of being good enough. Because, once again, it is those deep connections that we have with people that are an incredible currency of self-esteem.

Hence, take your 'passive pants' off. Make your wants be heard by those around you and actively ask others to meet your needs. And don't be afraid to put them above someone else's. Be selfish about them. Realise that ***you must be the greatest advocate of your own needs*** and take responsibility for meeting them. And that applies to every situation of your life. Even something simple like the conversations you have with others, for example. Because expressing your needs can also take the form of just steering a conversation to what interests you. I.e., being selfish about what you want to talk about, and expecting people to listen to you and show an interest as well. Adopt the mindset that it doesn't matter if the topic you want to talk about is objectively interesting or not and start assuming that: ***whatever is interesting to you, is interesting in general***. Don't be afraid to share yourself and make sure you get the airtime you think you deserve. And if the other person isn't interested then that's ok, that's their right, but you deserve to share yourself. Plus, people like listening to people that are passionate about something even when they don't share the same level of interest in the topic. They find the passion alone captivating. It's the reason so many people watch things like Top Gear or the Bake Off even when they aren't petrol heads or full-time hobby bakers themselves.

But captivating others shouldn't even be the main goal, that's just a nice side effect. What's important is that you get into the habit of being clear about what you want, expressing it, and as a result of that, consistently signal yourself that your wants and therefore YOU matter.

Side Note: Asking someone for a favour is low-key also a good way of showing the other person that you respect and appreciate their abilities to meet your needs, which will earn you real likeability and trustworthiness.

Unpopular opinion: It's good to get your walls up.

To finish this chapter, let's revisit something I stated in the introduction of this eBook. If you recall, I said that part of the reason we are constantly diminishing our self-esteem is that we have stopped seeking the approval that we want for our goals, behaviours, and even our thoughts from **ourselves**. And that we instead, have programmed ourselves to be people-pleasers, who are entirely focused on meeting the expectations of the **others**, satisfying the needs of the **others**, worrying about the feelings and problems of the **others**, hoping that it will enable us to win their approval and thereby find happiness and contentment. And I said that not only is this a pretty dangerous thing to do as you are putting your entire happiness in the hands of someone else, but also that social media has made this an impossible task to complete through tricking our brain into assuming that our tribe – those people, whose approval really matters – is infinitely bigger than it actually is.

However, what I didn't tell you at the time is the underlying reason for why this task has become impossible to complete. And that is: **You can't possibly satisfy everyone's feelings.**

What most people seem to ignore is that just like the others can't possibly know exactly what's good for you, you can't possibly know with complete certainty what's good for others. Even if you are the best people-pleaser, approval-seeker, and conflict-avoider the world has ever seen, you won't be able to sustain a success rate of 100%. Every one of us is so unique that there is no way of completely understanding someone else's needs and priorities, and accommodate them accordingly.

And yet too many people these days are trying too hard to get invested into another person's life and especially their problems. People are going way beyond just supporting their peers with their issues these days and put themselves in a position where they start feeling the same pain as them. Or even worse, where they start taking responsibility for trying to solve the other person's problems, hoping that doing so will give them the validation they seek, only to then end in frustration and questioning their self-worth as they are trying to solve an impossible task.

I call this **toxic empathy**. Because nobody can solve your problems for you and equally you can't solve anyone's problems for someone else. It's an impossible task. For reasons, such as our individuality and the fact that we hide our third face from the world, we will never know what a *completely* satisfying solution looks like for others' problems.

Hence, a big part of our mission to develop a healthy level of selfishness must be to re-establish where we end and where others start. In other words, **we must define boundaries**. We must shift away from constantly worrying about others

and redirect our focus to ourselves, our own goals, our own intrinsic wants and be primarily concerned with solving our own problems rather than those of the others. Not only will this eliminate the risk of not being able to solve another person's issues and therefore fail to win their approval. It will provoke quite the opposite. Redirecting our focus to ourselves, as we have alluded to above, allows us to earn the currencies of self-esteem that come with working towards our own goals.

Now, as I said in the introduction I am not suggesting that you should completely stop caring about everyone around you because we do need a good tribe in our lives. And I believe that being there for others, showing unconditional support, helping others to see them succeed in their own lives, and making them feel loved and wanted, especially when they are under pressure in their own lives is arguably the highest form of satisfaction you can get.

However, **we must not be "too nice"**. We mustn't end up in a situation where we spend all of our time thinking about and solving someone else's issues, hoping that doing so will make the others like us, and subsequently give us the validation that we seek. That's a pointless endeavour. Because I can guarantee you another thing: **You have no control over whether other people will like you or not**. People make up their minds about things in ways that you don't understand. In ways that they might not even understand themselves! Someone might dislike you because you subconsciously remind them of their old PE teacher they hated with a passion in school, and they're completely unaware of it. Someone might resent you because they are projecting their own issues onto you. And there is nothing you can do about that. We are all so complex that you will never be able to fully grasp someone's decision-making criteria.

Hence, draw your lines and protect your boundaries. Be selfish about who you want to help with their problems and to what extent you want to help them. And if they don't like that, then that's their problem. While you can try to see the other person's problems and support them in addressing it, ***you are not responsible for solving their problems. That's their task.***

Interlude

Now, before we continue, take a quick breather...

Take a moment to reflect on what you have read so far. Maybe even take a pen and paper to hand as you do so. How do you feel as you're thinking about turning down your friend's ask for a favour? As you're thinking about rejecting someone's offer to give you advice? As you're thinking about being a bit more selfish? As you're thinking about asking someone else to do something for you that requires them to put their needs behind yours? As you're thinking about challenging someone's opinion? As you're thinking about cutting a conversation short so you can move to a topic that's more interesting to you? As you're thinking about telling someone that you don't want to help them with their problem?

Nervous? Anxious? Doubtful? Afraid? Like you don't know if you have the heart to do it?

Well, you better get used to it. Because here comes the hardest but the most important part of rewiring your brain to stop feeling like an imposter, tackling your insecurities, and reinstating that healthy balance between seeking approval from others and yourself.

Step 3:

Accept discomfort

All of the above, rejecting others, being selfish, saying what you want, etc. **will get messy**. Let me disillusion you. It will be fucking hard work. Because people are not going to like the things you say and do. They will feel disappointed, sad, and even anger and resentment towards you. They will tell you that you are wrong, might call you names, and they might even say that they want nothing to do with you anymore.

And you will feel so uncomfortable. We are talking breaking-out-in-a-sweat-uncomfortable. Your Superego will flush you with feelings of guilt, doubt, fear, and anxiety. You will feel the urge to apologise, to say that you didn't mean it, and to go back to your old unhealthy habits. Because it is just so much easier to surrender yourself to your Superego, to stay silent, and to just put up with other people's shit.

Or is it?

Let's slow down for a moment and ask ourselves this: *What about the discomfort you feel if you stay where you are?*

What about the feeling of discomfort you get from constantly questioning whether there is something wrong with you? From never feeling good enough?

What about the feeling of discomfort you get from feeling left out in conversations because you are always holding back out of fear about what others are going to think of your opinions? From having to work overtime because you weren't strong enough to say 'no' to taking on extra work? From feeling like something is wrong but you can't really put your finger on it as you are suppressing your Id?

Interesting perspective, isn't it. See, that's where the error is in most people's thinking. We only ever consider one side of the coin. We ignore the discomfort of our current situation and over-inflate the discomfort that comes with changing our behaviour. However, the uncomfortable truth is: **Discomfort is inevitable**. It's an unavoidable recurring instance, if you like it or not. Even in your current situation.

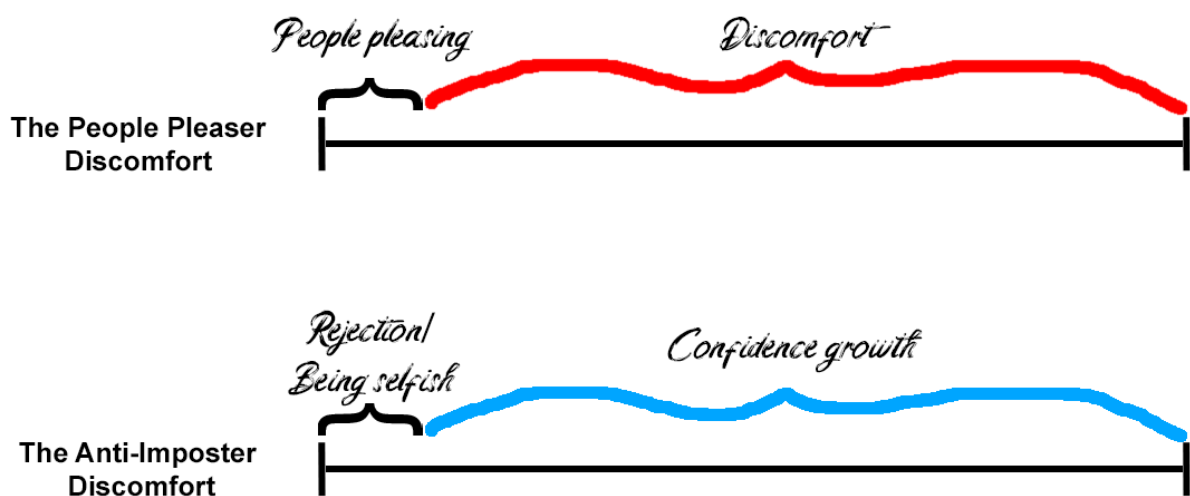
But something tells me you already know that. Something tells me you are aware of the discomfort of your current situation, otherwise you wouldn't have downloaded this eBook and read it up to this point. And hopefully I didn't just ruin your day by telling you that discomfort is inevitable. But if I have, here is your relief: As the above shows, *not every discomfort is the same*. In fact, there is a HUGE difference between two types of discomfort that nobody ever tells you about. And that is:

The 'people-pleaser discomfort', i.e., the staying where you are, the living a life below its full potential, and the feeling unfulfilled by, for instance, always letting others dictate how to spend your time is **long-term discomfort**. The feelings of not being good enough, the questioning yourself, the over analysing what you did wrong and what you should have done instead preoccupy your mind for much longer. (Ever sat there staring into space for hours on end not being able to concentrate because you are overthinking something? I know I have plenty of times.). This type of discomfort sticks with you. In fact, it only gets reinforced!

Because even your hardest efforts to please people, seek approval from others, and avoid conflict at all costs will eventually fail because of all the reasons described in chapter 1 and 2. And not only once but over and over again, until you permanently damage your self-image.

The ‘anti-imposter discomfort’, however, i.e., the feelings of guilt, doubt, fear, and anxiety that you get from embracing rejection and selfishness is **short-term discomfort**. As opposed to the people-pleaser discomfort, this type of uneasiness fades away pretty quickly. It gets replaced by realisations such as that there is real power in being disliked, that it enables you to be less distracted and to know that the people you spend time with are real friends that you genuinely want to be around because they make you feel good about yourself. Over time that might even make you like moments of discomfort. Because you recognise that it is those moments of discomfort where you can make a real difference in how you see yourself. That it is those moments of discomfort where you get the choice to show yourself what you want to stand for and provoke the long-lasting improvements in your confidence that come with those choices.

The question is, which type of discomfort are you going to choose?



Hence, **accept that discomfort is inevitable**. This is one of the most important realisations I had on my journey to rediscovering my self-belief. Because once you do accept that, things get a lot easier. Accepting that things will get uncomfortable weakens the feelings of discomfort when they occur. Through acceptance you are mentally putting yourself in a state of constant anticipation that these feelings are going to come. You just don't know when. As a result, they are not going to overwhelm you as much when they do eventually occur. And thus you are able to overcome them quicker. Besides, accepting that discomfort is inevitable acts as a huge relief for your constant anxiety. Because you stop worrying about how to avoid discomfort. (If it's inevitable there's no point worrying about how to prevent it), and in turn, free your mind to rather think about how to manage it.

The power of conflict.

With that in mind, let's look at one of the most intense forms of discomfort. One that most of us are trying to avoid at all costs. And which is therefore arguably the main motivator for putting us into people-pleasing mode: **Conflict**.

Most people hate conflict. And who can blame them, right? Because conflict, arguments, and disagreements can be really ugly and destructive. They usually drive us to spit out our most unfiltered thoughts, say mean things, make us and the other person feel bad, and confront us about our deepest insecurities. In those moments rational thinking has left the chat and we are running on pure emotion. They have the potential to ruin relationships and form a real hatred between people. And they bring out a scary side of us that we sometimes didn't even know we had. But this destructive capacity is also what makes arguments beautiful in a way. And ironically a really powerful tool for building deep relationships.

Because this destructive capacity brings energy and vitality into our relationships. Conflicts break us out of certainty and predictability into uncertainty, where all energy and passion comes from. It creates moments of not knowing whether you are going to split up with your partner, whether you are going to stay friends with your best mate, or whether you're going to go through with your business negotiations. In other words, it shows what your relationship is really made of. Conflict will test whether you are built on strong foundations that won't let this disagreement shatter them, such as honesty and trust, i.e., the basis for any healthy relationship.

And if you pass the test, it will only bond you closer together. Because that moment of potential loss will make you find a new appreciation for what you have. The conflict resolution will help you gain a deeper level of understanding and empathy for each other. And that moment of heightened emotions will show you that you are both passionate about each other, that you really care about each other, and that you are willing to invest time and effort into each other to make things work.

Hence, don't be afraid to end up in arguments. Cancel your subscription to conflict-avoidance and realise that **meaningful relationships require direct contact**.

However, that's not all. In addition to relationship-building, conflict also has a psychological benefit. Which is that it frees you from all the things that are pent up inside you, the resentment you have towards others, a situation, or even yourself. It allows your Id to vent and send yourself an incredibly strong signal that you and your views are important and that you believe in them and yourself so much in fact that you are willing to fight to defend them. And that is incredibly powerful.

Otherwise, as alluded to above, if you hold back, you're going to beat yourself up afterwards. (Been there too many times). You set yourself up to feel less alive and less engaged as you end up suppressing your Id and thereby prevent yourself from showing up as your true self.

And that also has a knock-on effect because, see, the others aren't stupid. The others will pick up on your inauthenticity. They can tell that you may think differently but aren't saying anything. And that's not a good look. It makes you seem a bit fake and dishonest, which are not the kind of qualities anyone wants to be around. It also makes it harder for them to be friends with you because they won't know how to behave around you. They won't know, for instance, how much they can push you with banter out of fear of upsetting you, and so, they end up engaging less with you.

Hence, realise that speaking up is good. And learn to be real with others. That means not being afraid to just look someone in the eye and say it how it is. That means not looking away or closing yourself off but showing feelings, including anger or disappointment. That means being honest and sharing your opinions regardless of what the others think. If you're in a work meeting, for example, remember that you're not there to be worried about what others think of you. You're not there to overly laugh at others' jokes and worry about making others like you. Instead, you're there to worry about your company, your colleagues, and your clients. So, be focused on how you can serve them, how asking questions and raising uncomfortable truths is going to help you with that. Not being afraid to debate, challenge an opinion, and just say how it is will earn you much more respect than being a conflict-avoider ever will. (Plus, if you get known for being honest, not being afraid to share the uncomfortable truth, your compliments gain so much more weight, people will trust much more that what you say you really mean and that you genuinely compliment them and aren't just being "nice".)

Now I know what you're thinking: "But what if I hurt the other person? What if I go too far and lose them as a friend? I don't know if I have the heart to do that." Don't worry, I feel you. These used to be my exact thoughts. Especially when I considered breaking up with my ex-girlfriend. I always thought "No, I can't do that to her, she is so in love with me, she wouldn't be able to take it, I would literally break her world apart." But guess what, in the end, she moved on quicker than me.

Because the truth is: **People aren't fragile**. They are in fact a lot stronger and more resilient than we think. They can take the bad news, your disagreement, or heartbreak. They will overcome the uncomfortable truth of things. Because **upset is temporary**. No matter how much sadness, pain, anger, upset you or someone else has to bear, always remember that emotions are temporary. Feelings shift and so people will overcome any sort of negative down phase.

Obviously, there are exceptions, and you will encounter people who turn their upset with you into a permanent hatred. But those are not people you want to have any relationship with anyway. These people have a strong need to feel certain and significant by making others feel bad and wrong. They are unlikely to meet their needs in a more healthy, positive, growth-oriented way.

And if anything, this reality makes not shying away from conflict even more important. Because if you don't give people the chance to reject you, you'll never know who your real friends are. If anything, those that do reject you, you should thank for not wasting your time and just removing themselves from your circle so you can focus on who is actually important to you.

On a side note, I just want to acknowledge here that arguments do obviously get very ugly sometimes. There will be times where people make accusations and insult you in horrible ways that may deeply hurt you. In those moments, it is

crucial to differentiate between what you know is true and what the others believe is true. Because the only criticism that will ever touch you is internal one. The criticism that others put on you, but that you don't agree with won't touch you. Hence, in those moments remind yourself that: The others will never truly know you. They will never have all the facts about you and your situation. So how can they form any real judgement, any valid criticism? They can't.

For that purpose, it is also really important to become aware of your flaws. Because if you know your errors, you also know which things aren't our flaws, and therefore which things the others can't use to hurt you. So be honest with yourself and become aware of your faults. Accept that nobody, including you, is perfect and that there are things about you that aren't all sunshine and roses. However, if we know this and more importantly accept that reality, our flaws lose their power over us in making us feel bad about ourselves and we are able to disarm others to use them against us. (A great example of this is the final rap battle in 8 mile, in which Eminem owns his flaws in his stint and therefore completely disarms his opponent's ability to use them against him.)

Unfortunately, being armed with this knowledge is not enough. The next time you are in a situation in which you are trying to speak up, you will still experience doubt, fear and anxiety. The next time someone disapproves of you, you will still feel the urge to go back into your old habits and do everything to get them to like you. However, you can't let that get in the way of being yourself. You need to accept that things will get messy, that you will feel so uncomfortable, and that you might end up in conflicts, but that's ok, that's part of the process. The key is to keep pushing yourself out of that toxic comfort zone. You need to do the opposite of what your parents always told you to do.

And dear reader if there is only one thing that you take away from this eBook, then please let it be the following:

Step 4:

Act first, think later.

The final lesson of this eBook is to “**do** the stuff that makes you feel uncomfortable **first** and work through the emotional backlash (guilt, anxiety, fear) afterwards.”

Read that again. This is arguably the most important lesson of this eBook.

I need you to understand that everything that I have told you so far, all the little mindset tips and epiphanies that I have shared with you, *they all mean nothing* without one thing: **Taking action.**

It is great to understand that embracing rejection will define what you stand for and help you gain the currencies of self-esteem as a result of that. However, you're only going to experience these benefits *when you actually reject someone.*

It's great to realise that being selfish is actually healthy and needed if you are looking to boost your confidence and even your overall well being. But if you don't actively put your needs before those of the others, you're never actually going to experience these confidence boosts.

This is absolutely crucial to understand and internalise. Too many people these days in their addiction to self-improvement listen to all the podcasts and read all the books... **But they don't implement what they learned.**

And that renders everything pointless. Without taking action you will never actually enjoy the benefits of what you learn.

Action is the key to becoming who you are meant to be. It is what will make or break all your plans. If you miss out on putting everything of the above into action you will still have an unhappy life, no profile, no recognition, and no success in regaining your sense of being good enough. Taking action is what will help you grow as a person more than anything else. Without action you won't make mistakes that you can learn from. Without action you won't provoke your luck. Without action you won't reach your goals. Without action you won't find the partner of your dreams. Without action you won't build great friendships. I.e. without action you won't actually earn the currencies of self-esteem.

Hence, take back responsibility for your own self-esteem by embracing the importance of taking action. Think of it like the reverse of what Uncle Ben told Peter Parker in Spiderman: "With great responsibility, comes great power." Once you start taking responsibility for your actions and decisions, you gain back full control of your life and your self-esteem.

Now, I understand that doing so can be scary. You will feel the fear of what others will think of you, the fear of being wrong, of embarrassing yourself, of others seeing you are nervous, of being a laughing stock, of coming across weird, etc. This list of fears and worries that our mind can come up with is virtually endless.

But we can't let that define our behaviours. Because here is the thing: ***Things are never actually as bad as they seem.***

Our mind tends to exaggerate and catastrophize stuff. It is an absolute master at creating worst-case scenarios, especially when you are overthinking stuff. But

here is the thing: ***Our subconscious can't actually differentiate between reality and fiction.***

And that means, when our subconscious is drawing up these worst-case scenarios it is at the same time making you think that they are real (even though they aren't), thereby putting you under stress, discomfort and fear, which is not helpful at all. Ryan Holiday illustrates this point quite nicely in his book *Courage is Calling* in which he tells the story of Ulysses S. Grant, a military officer and the 18th president of the United States:

"Grant was on a long journey across East Texas in the midst of dangerous territory that included the threat of wolves. Together with his companion, Grant heard the most unearthly howling of wolves but they couldn't see anything through the high prairie grass. Scared to death Grant wanted to turn around and secretly prayed that his companion would suggest it, wanting nothing more than to get to safety. The other officer then asked 'Grant, how many wolves do you think there are in that pack?'. Not wanting to look stupid or a coward, Grant tried to causally underestimate the threat that terrified him and said "Oh, about 20." Suddenly, Grant and the other officer came upon the source of their threat. There resting were just two wolves. All the stress, anxiety, and fear was caused by just two wolves."

The lesson Grant learned that day was that: ***There is always more until you count.*** Critics, obstacles, doubters, threats. Our mind loves exaggerating the threats that we're facing, but the reality is never that bad.

However, if we allow ourselves to overthink, this is exactly what is going to happen. You end up freezing in what you do as you are evaluating all the things that could go wrong and prevent yourself from taking the action that will help you improve life.

Lack of action also makes you prone to suffering from the **Zeigarnik effect**. The Zeigarnik effect suggests that when you open a loop, e.g., by thinking about what could happen, you want to know what the outcome is, and you will be worried about the potential outcome until you close that loop. E.g., if you see that girl or guy on the underground and think they are cute but you don't have the balls to go over and talk to them, you will probably end up regretting it on your walk home. And you are likely to think about what you could have said and how things could have gone for the rest of that evening. I.e., the loop stays open. This is incredibly problematic because it is majorly distracting. It draws away your focus from things that might be more important. It prevents you from concentrating on what you had planned for the rest of that day and being present in the moment. However, if you had gone over and just introduced yourself, complimented them on their looks and asked for their Insta, you would have prevented any of that overthinking. Even if they would have rejected you, the loop would have been closed. You wouldn't have had to worry about what could have been because you got the certainty, allowing you to move on and stay present in life.

What I am trying to say is: **Action is always better than no action.**

A fear unchallenged grows stronger and eventually controls you. Only if you dissolve it, your power will grow.

Hence, if you want to grow and regain feeling good enough, you have to take a leap into the dark. There is no way around it. There is always risk but if you never take the leap you'll never be forced to handle the risk and learn and grow. Because even if, like in the above example, you fail, taking action alone would have fuelled your confidence and your ability to endure discomfort.

Hence, learn to take action before the overthinking sets in - act first, think later. In doing so, you eliminate your brain's brilliant ability to draw up worst case scenarios and prevent yourself from taking the next step to boosting your self-esteem. Remind yourself of the lessons from chapter three and expect that things might get messy, but then take action anyway.

Now, you might be wondering at this point, what exact action you should take to rebuild your self-esteem. What we do in the AIC is - in line with the learnings from this eBook - to start with this: **Getting to know yourself**. Based on the notion that feeling secure in yourself is rooted in knowing what you stand for, knowing what excites and energises you and what doesn't and should therefore be rejected, we use a range of exercises under the header of "Unlocking the essence of you" that are intended to help you discover exactly that.

Have a look at the [AIC Cookbook](#) to see if this might be of interest to you.

But before I let you go, let me leave you with this...

One Last thing...

If after everything you have read above you are still sitting here thinking “I don’t know if I can do this, reject people, be selfish, tell others that I won’t help them... maybe I’ll just stay the people-pleaser that I am because it does work sometimes!”, consider this final story:

In 2019 an Australian nurse called Bronnie Ware, (now also TEDx speaker) published a book. But not just any book. Because Bronnie Ware isn't just any nurse. Ware was a palliative carer who had spent several years caring for patients in the last 12 weeks of their lives before they passed away. And as Ware describes herself, this was a life-changing experience for her. Because working with the dying and building close relationships with them led to a different kind of conversation. Conversations that I assume almost none of us have ever had in their life. Conversations about life and death. Conversations about regrets. But with a level of rawness, honesty, and intimacy that is undoubtedly incomparable to any of the 'deep talks' any of us have with our family and close friends. To honour her patients' wisdom, Ware therefore decided to summarise these epiphanies and regrets in a book called *The Top Five Regrets of the Dying*⁹, and the response was unimaginable. Ware got overwhelmed with millions of readers, thousands of requests and messages to share more of her experience and a huge interest from all over the world, leading to her book being translated into 32 languages and being cited by millions of people including Forbes, Wall St Journal, Marie Forleo, Lewis Howes, and Harvard Business Review.

What is striking is that the conversations Ware had with her patients about life regrets never involved things like never having owned a Lamborghini or a big

⁹<https://bronnieware.com/blog/regrets-of-the-dying/>

villa by the beach, which is what society seemingly values much more than it should these days.

Instead, the conversations that Ware had revolved much more around one painful regret. And that was: ***“I wish I’d had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me.”***

Let that sink in for a moment.

What this shows us is that the idea of not having fully lived life to its potential will damage us much more in the long-term than we realise... and definitely much more than the idea of acting outside of society’s expectations and not pleasing other people.

Hence, if I can have only one little impact on your life with this eBook, please let it be my encouragement to take care of yourself. You are already good enough the way you are. Learn to show that to yourself and live a life true to who you *really* are and what is *actually* important to you. Be it through applying the steps in this ebook, the advice of anyone else you resonate with or (most importantly) your own advice to yourself.

Thanks for reading and all the best,

Stefan



Hi, my name is Stefan, and just like you, I had (and still have) this little voice in my head telling me that... [continue reading](#)